

they'll need later to tackle the full-blown method.

I ask teams to adopt these simple rules:

1. Be tolerant of all mistakes the first time.
2. Never allow the same mistake to be made twice.

The first rule encourages people to get used to being compassionate about mistakes, especially the mistakes of others. Remember, most mistakes are caused by flawed systems, not bad people. The second rule gets the team started making proportional investments in prevention.

This simplified system works well. In fact, we used it at IMVU in the days before I discovered the Five Whys and the Toyota Production System. However, such a simplified system does not work effectively over the long term, as I found out firsthand. In fact, that was one of the things that drove me to first learn about lean production.

The strength and weakness of the simplified system is that it invites questions such as What counts as the same problem? What kinds of mistakes should we focus on? and Should we fix this individual problem or try to prevent a whole category of related problems? For a team that is just getting started, these questions are thought-provoking and can lay the groundwork for more elaborate methods to come. Ultimately, though, they do need answering. They need a complete adaptive process such as the Five Whys.

## Facing Unpleasant Truths

You will need to be prepared for the fact that Five Whys is going to turn up unpleasant facts about your organization, especially at the beginning. It is going to call for investments in prevention that come at the expense of time and money that could be invested in new products or features. Under pressure, teams may feel that they don't have time to waste on analyzing root causes even though it would give them more time in the long term. The process